

VARIED SENTENCE STRUCTURES

Mixing up how your sentences are built



1 What is it?

Varied Sentence Structures

Varied sentence structures means **mixing up the length and type** of your sentences — short and long, simple and complex — instead of writing every sentence the same way.

short + long + simple + complex = rhythm

2 See it in action

A simple sentence

She ran. One clause, direct and punchy.

A compound sentence

She ran, and her heart pounded. Two ideas joined with "and."

A complex sentence

Although she was exhausted, she kept running because stopping wasn't an option.

A minor sentence

No time. No choice. Deliberately incomplete, for effect.



Look here!

Read your own writing **aloud** — if every sentence feels the same length and rhythm, that's a sign to deliberately mix in something shorter or longer.

FUN FACT

A famous piece of writing advice says: "this sentence has five words. Here are five more words. Five-word sentences are fine. But several together become monotonous. Listen to what is happening. The writing is getting boring." — proving the point by demonstrating it.

3 Why writers use it

Varied Sentence Structures help writers: control rhythm and pace so writing doesn't feel repetitive or monotonous, create emphasis by contrasting sentence lengths, and mirror the emotion of a scene (short and sharp for panic, long and flowing for calm).

Examiners specifically reward deliberate sentence variety — an unbroken run of similar-length sentences, however well-written each one is individually, usually reads as less skilled overall.

4 Don't mix it up!

Varied Sentence Structures

- Mixes **length and type** of sentence
- A whole-text technique
- Controls rhythm across a passage

Sentence Length

- Focuses on a **single** sentence's length
- One tool within variety
- Controls emphasis in one moment



Watch out!

Don't vary sentence structure randomly for its own sake — the best writers choose a sentence length and type because it matches the moment, not just to prove they can.



You got this!

When analysing a text, look for a **sudden change** in sentence type or length — that shift is almost always deliberate and worth naming.

5 Quick recap

Mixes short and long sentences

Mixes simple and complex types

Creates rhythm and prevents monotony



Good spot!

Try writing four sentences about the same short moment, each a completely different length and structure — notice how differently each one feels to read.